> created the conditions for mobility between these contiguous realms on a previously unimaginable scale. The expansion of the Shansabanid lands to include vast areas that had traditionally fallen outside the *dar al-Islam* presented the parvenu Ghurids and their agents with a double imperative: to project their authority and legitimize their position within the *dar al-Islam* and to provide effective governance in the newly acquired Indian territories that had formerly stood without it.

While this description of the Shansabanis is – again – not strictly incorrect, it accrues principally from two parts of Sana'i's elephant, *viz.* those elucidated by the rather rigidly circumscribed disciplinary *loci* of history and art-architectural history. Fortunately, the Minaret of Jam Archaeological Project (MJAP), directed by Dr. David Thomas, has recently brought to light a third pachydermal part, making apprehension of the whole "beast" that much more attainable: rigorous archaeological surveys and excavations by MJAP specialists during the mid-2000s in central Afghanistan's Ghur province, at the site of Jam-Firuzkuh (Figure I.2) – now generally believed to be the *sard-sir* encampment or summer "capital" of one branch of the Shansabani confederacy (cf. Chapters 2–4) – provide us with invaluable data of the *material* conditions of the lives of the Shansabani elites and at least some of their cohabitants at the locality.[26]

Making sense of the whole range of seemingly unrelated or only circumstantial data for the Shansabanis, as well as the existing *lacunae* therein, is not unlike the sensation of following the elephant's trunk (for example), only to discover an entirely new and seemingly dissimilar yet ultimately connected part of an organic terrain. It has necessitated forays into the additional discipline of anthropology, and therein the study of nomadic pastoralists and other transhumant populations, often referred to as "barbarians."[27] The principal hypothesis animating the present project is that, during the first few decades of the twelfth century, the Shansabanis experienced an ancestral shift from being *more* nomadic and/or seasonally transhumant ("barbarians") to *more* sedentist power-brokers, not necessarily reaching either end of the nomad–urban continuum.[28] Recently, Patricia Crossley further clarified that:

> [n]omads can be designated more concretely as pastoralists – people at some moment in time depending primarily upon the care and processing of animals for a living, but always living and trading within a broader context of agricultural, urban economies.[29]

Following Crossley, then, for convenience I use the less cumbersome "nomadism" and "transhumance" and their adjectival derivatives to encompass the full range of nomadic pastoralism and seasonal transhumance.

As for the Shansabanis and the consequential changes to their lifeways,